

Originally Processed With FOIA(s):
2009-0275-S

FOIA Number:
2009-0275-S

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OA/ID Number: 91112
Folder ID Number: 91112-002

Folder Title:
Presidential Telephone Calls - Memorandum of Conversations 8/22/90 - 10/5/90

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THE WHITE HOUSE

WASHINGTON

MEMCON

MEMORANDUM OF TELEPHONE CONVERSATION

SUBJECT: Telephone Call from Chancellor Helmut Kohl of the Federal Republic of Germany (U)

PARTICIPANTS: The President
Helmut Kohl, Chancellor
Notetaker: Robert Hutchings, NSC Staff
Interpreter: Gisela Marcuse

DATE, TIME: September 11, 1990, 12:36 - 12:46 p.m.
AND PLACE: The Oval Office

The President: Hello, Helmut! How are you? I wanted to give you a report on my meetings in Helsinki. (U)

Chancellor Kohl: It made an excellent impression. I spoke with Gorbachev yesterday on the telephone. We talked about other things, but also about this. He is very pleased. (Ø)

The President: I am glad. He came across with a stronger statement than we had anticipated. We got everything we wanted. He is very concerned about the use of force, but I had a very frank and open discussion with him about what might happen if there should be a provocation. We addressed ourselves to the food question also. I think he agrees with us that regular shipments of foodstuffs are banned by the UN sanctions. However, some kinds of humanitarian shipments, especially for children, could be considered so long as there are international observers to ensure that the food gets to the children. (Ø)

He thinks the sanctions will work. I am beginning to think so, too. Yesterday, Fahd, Ozal, and Mitterrand all told me the sanctions are having a serious impact on Iraq. So I am basically pleased and just wanted to touch base with you. (Ø)

A second issue: I am very sorry I won't be able to come on October 3. Brent has already conveyed that to Horst Teltschik. It is a horribly complex time for me. I hope you understand. I hate letting you down like this. (Ø)

Chancellor Kohl: George, let me say on that last point that of course I have total understanding for your position. I indicated that when we last spoke. (U)

The President: I know you did. I appreciate your understanding. (U)

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24 8/21/2009
2000-0429-F

Chancellor Kohl: Among friends, it must be possible to say when there are problems without creating a big hubbub. We have come a long way together and have a long way to go. Let me suggest on that day that you send a message to the Germans. (Ø)

The President: Absolutely. Would you like a televised or a written message? (Ø)

Chancellor Kohl: A televised message would be very good. (Ø)

The President: We will get a tape and have our people contact your Embassy to get the right size and specifications. I will get that out well in advance. (Ø)

Chancellor Kohl: That is a very good idea. As to Helsinki and what you told me about the Gulf situation, I totally agree with you. I welcome it if sanctions are taking effect. In my discussions with Jim Baker I will try to work together with him as to what we Germans can do. At the very latest, in one week's time we will be able to say what the Germans can do and will do. I want to help, but you know the limits we have. But under no circumstances do I want a situation in which the Germans are made out to be the number one exporter, but when responsible action is required they are not there. That is not our policy. (Ø)

The President: We understand that. Don't worry about that. Maybe things are moving out there. I still worry about terrorist acts, but I am encouraged that those close to the scene think the sanctions are taking hold. (Ø)

Chancellor Kohl: I hope so, too. (U)

The President: It was good talking to you, Helmut. (U)

-- End of Conversation --